

Subj: **Rare Bird Report**
Date: 12/30/1999 5:39:47 PM Mountain Standard Time
From: chickadd@juno.com (BB Hahn)
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NO review

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COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS SIGHT RECORD FORM

Results:

Species: American Golden-Plover

Date: September 13, 1999

Number of birds seen: One

Sex: Unknown

Plumage: Juvenile? Fresh adult? I'm confused! See below.

Locality: Beebe Draw, Lower Latham Reservoir

Elevation: Est. 4,600'

Nearest town: Greeley

County: Weld

Time observed: 2:00 to 4:30 p.m.

Duration of observation: Off and on for 2.5 hours.

Other observers with you: Todd Myers and another couple, whose names I failed to get.

Other observers who saw the bird independently: Todd Dilley, later that afternoon; Tony Leukering, et al, the following day, I believe. More observers later.

Light conditions: Clear skies, sunny.

Optical equipment: Swarovski HD80 AT Scope and Swarovski 10x42 binocs

Distance from bird: 30 yards or so.

Describe the bird's behavior: The bird flew in while I was watching the Ruddy Turnstone, so I didn't see its axillaries to determine if they were dark (as in Black-bellied). It foraged quickly and with gusto in the shallow water for 10 minutes or so, then spent most of the rest of the time I viewed it standing (on one or two legs) and at rest on its belly on the ground.

Describe the bird (what you actually saw): The back was gray and heavily

spotted with whitish marks. I couldn't discern any dark brown, as in a juvie. I really couldn't discern the primary extension. The bird had a pale golden wash to its breast, and, per the Shorebirds book by Hayman, et al.; in non-breeding, "Breast washed pale greyish, initially with dull yellowish fringes...", I thought this also pointed to an adult in very fresh basic plumage. I was confused by the supercilium, which, according to all the books, should look whitish and conspicuous (or striking in non-breeding adults). I did not feel the supercilium was that striking; however, the bird did have the dusky spot on the ear coverts and a mark in front of its eye. It never did open its wings; it looked tired and fed only a small amount, then stood around or lay down the rest of the time.

Describe the bird's song and call if heard: It did call, but only a one-syllable sound I hesitate to describe - not a lot of help to me.

Describe the habitat in which you observed the bird: Marshy area with shallow running and still waters. Vegetation cropped well by cattle.

How did you eliminate similarly appearing species: vs. Black-bellied Plover. I considered Black-bellied, but this bird looked longer-necked and not "hunched over" to me. Subjective, since there was no other bird like it to compare. It seemed to have more leg above the joint and a heavier bill.

Fortunately, others saw the bird and confirmed my sighting...

What is your prior experience with this and similarly appearing species: September 2, 1998, saw an AMGP at Ft. Lyon (Rds HH and 16) with Brandon Percival. Saw many, many Pacific Golden-Plovers in Hawaii in 1997.

List books if they helped in your identification: NGS Field Guide; "Shorebirds - An Identification Guide" by Peter Hayman, et al.

This report was written from notes taken during observation.

Reporting observer: BB Hahn, 2915 Hodgen Road, Black Forest, CO 80921 719-495-0647

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